Mindy Hoover, PhD

melyndahoover.com | linkedin.com/in/melyndahoover

UX Researcher with 10+ years of mixed methods research experience across VR, ads, developer tools, and consumer hardware. PhD in HCI. Specializes in translating user data into product strategy.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

UX Researcher, Meta

Oct 2023 – Present | Seattle, WA

Converted from contract (TEKsystems) to full-time employee, Aug 2024

- Led hardware UX research for a 0-to-1 VR product from early concept through launch readiness, combining surveys, interviews, heuristic evaluations, and longitudinal user studies to define product requirements and inform go/no-go decisions.
- Managed external research vendor partnerships, owning study design, participant recruitment (n=60+), and multi-week data collection programs with cross-functional teams of 10+ stakeholders.
- Owned the comfort benchmarking program, designing and validating research instruments in collaboration with engineering, design, and product stakeholders to establish user acceptance criteria for a new product category.
- Established research operations practices including standardized external research approval workflows, vendor safety frameworks, and best practices documentation — trained non-researchers on study methodologies to scale lightweight evaluations across product teams.
- Reviewed hardware architecture design documents and served as a key UX decision-maker in cross-functional product reviews, providing user experience context that directly influenced product direction and feature prioritization.
- Leveraged AI tools (Claude) to accelerate research workflows including literature reviews, qualitative data synthesis, study planning, and stakeholder communication — reducing turnaround time across concurrent studies.

UX Researcher, Google

May 2022 – Mar 2023 | Seattle, WA

- Partnered with Software Engineers and Product Managers to map complex developer user journeys, prioritize research questions, and influence product strategy for Flutter.
- Conducted interviews, focus groups, and surveys with developers across the US and Europe, identifying pain points and priorities that shaped Flutter's 2023 API development strategy for desktop platform support.
- Evaluated new feature adoption and user satisfaction through moderated and unmoderated studies, identifying usability barriers that informed engineering priorities for subsequent releases.

Research Portfolio Manager, Design Interactive

Jan 2022 – May 2022 | Remote

- Led cross-functional teams of researchers, engineers, and PMs to deliver user-centered augmented reality training tools for the U.S. Army and Navy.
- Identified emerging research opportunities in the XR training space and authored grant proposals for U.S. government funding consideration.

- Managed multiple concurrent research programs to evaluate training processes, identify usability gaps and inform new training system designs.

Research Assistant, VR Applications Center — Iowa State University

Jan 2013 – Dec 2021 | Ames, IA

- Collaborated with cross-functional teams from Boeing, John Deere, and Collins Aerospace to design and evaluate AR/VR applications for enterprise training and simulation.
- Planned and executed 150+ in-person and remote user studies including usability tests, A/B tests, interviews, and diary studies, training junior researchers on study protocols.
- Developed scalable remote research processes for VR participant recruiting and automated data collection, increasing sample diversity and study efficiency.
- Published 18 peer-reviewed papers on user-centered XR research in top venues including ACM CHI and IEEE VR.

UX Research Intern, Google Ads

May 2018 – Aug 2018 | New York, NY

- Designed and facilitated an 8-day diary study (n=50) using DScout to capture user perceptions of advertising formats, producing actionable recommendations for improving ad experiences and conversion rates.
- Conducted usability studies on new ad format designs and applied card sorting and participatory design methods to shape information architecture.

EDUCATION

Doctor of Philosophy in Human Computer Interaction — Iowa State University
Dissertation: *Adaptive XR Training Systems Design, Implementation, and Evaluation*
Master of Science in Human Computer Interaction & Mechanical Engineering — Iowa State University
Thesis: *An Evaluation of the Microsoft HoloLens for a Manufacturing Guided-Assembly Task*
Bachelor of Science in Mechanical Engineering — Iowa State University

SKILLS

Research Methods: Usability Testing, Interviews, Surveys, Focus Groups, A/B Testing, Card Sorting, Diary Studies, Participatory Design, Heuristic Evaluation, Cognitive Walkthrough, Workshop Facilitation, Longitudinal Studies, Remote & In-Person Research
Analysis Methods: Statistical Analysis, Qualitative Coding, Thematic Analysis, Affinity Diagrams, Personas, Task Analysis, Journey Mapping, Competitive Analysis, Mixed Methods Research, Research Synthesis
Tools: Claude, R, Python, SQL, Qualtrics, DScout, UserTesting, Miro, FigJam, Optimal Workshop, Excel/Google Sheets, Prolific, Unity 3D
Domains: AI-Augmented Research Workflows, Research Operations, XR/VR/AR, Developer Tools, Consumer Hardware, Ads, Aviation

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS & COMMUNITY

- Guest Editor, *Frontiers in Computer Science* — Co-edited special issue on remote XR research (2023)
- Workshop Co-Organizer, ACM CHI 2021 — Co-hosted First CHI Workshop on Remote XR Research
- 18 peer-reviewed publications including IEEE VR, ACM CHI, and ASME JCISE
- Google Scholar: scholar.google.com/citations?user=uFscDTIAAAAJ